MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 3: Restoration Drama

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Restoration drama turns changing theatrical institutions and fashionable social codes into performances of wit, desire, reputation, and authority.

Start with a picture

A group knows how to speak elegantly, but every conversation also tests who has status, money, or the right to judge. The audience enjoys the skill while watching its social consequences.

1. Theatre after 1660

The restored monarchy, patents, court connections, indoor venues, scenic practices, and professional actresses shape the theatrical world. These conditions do not produce one identical audience or attitude, but they affect dramatic possibilities.

Consider the difference between a written remark and a remark delivered by an actor with a pause, gesture, or concealed listener nearby.

2. Comedy of manners

The form examines the codes of a fashionable society through dialogue, intrigue, and social performance. Marriage, sexuality, money, and reputation are recurrent pressures. Repartee can be both attractive and aggressive.

A witty character is not necessarily morally reliable. The audience’s enjoyment of cleverness can coexist with criticism of how it is used.

3. The Way of the World

The proviso scene makes intimacy into negotiation. Fainall’s coercion and the role of legal protection expose property within the supposedly private world of love. The play’s comic intelligence includes recognition of material dependence.

4. A later inheritor: The School for Scandal

Sheridan’s 1777 play uses disguise, gossip, and exposure in a later social and theatrical setting. It can be studied as an inheritor of the comedy-of-manners tradition, but it should not be dated to the first Restoration generation.

The screen scene shows why staging matters: physical concealment and revelation alter the authority of what people claim.

5. Moral controversy and limits

Criticism of the stage raises questions about representation, audience pleasure, and supposed moral corruption. A play can satirise pretension while still depending on elite social codes. Exposing several wrongdoers does not by itself remove the system that rewards reputation management.

6. A scene-based method

Identify who knows what, who can leave, who controls resources, and how the stage distributes visibility. Analyse a verbal exchange and an action together. This produces a stronger account than calling the entire era immoral or sophisticated.

Quick check

1. Does manners mean only politeness? **No; it includes social codes and their pressures.**
2. Is Sheridan’s play contemporary with the Restoration’s beginning? **No.**
3. Can wit exercise power? **Yes.**

Build an exam answer

1. Define the social codes of manners comedy.
2. Explain theatrical conditions.
3. Use Congreve’s negotiation and property.
4. Analyse Sheridan as a later inheritor.
5. Evaluate the relation between exposure and structural change.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not describe an entire period through a moral stereotype or confuse social cleverness with ethical innocence.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How does comedy of manners combine social pleasure with criticism?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Comedy of manners derives its pleasure from an audience’s recognition of social codes, but that recognition also supplies a method of criticism. Wit reveals intelligence while exposing the uses of appearance, desire, and reputation. The form therefore neither simply endorses fashionable life nor stands entirely outside it.

The Way of the World shows this double relation through negotiation and intrigue. Clever speech can express attraction, yet property and permission remain decisive. The legal means of resisting coercion prevent the resolution from being explained only as the triumph of a good joke.

Sheridan’s later use of concealment and exposure provides another example. The screen scene turns social judgement into a theatrical event, making claims vulnerable to what the audience and characters can suddenly see. Its force depends on performance as much as on a general opposition between truth and falsehood.

A strong answer connects these methods with historical institutions and their limits. The laughter can reveal a social contradiction even where the ending preserves part of the hierarchy that produced it. That tension is central to the form’s critical interest.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Discuss the political contexts of writing Comedy of Manners.
2. Define Comedy of Manners and discuss its features.
3. Flourishing of comedies during the restoration.
4. Trace the features of Comedy of Manners in Richard Brinsley Sheridan’s The School for Scandal.